The Magic Finger

By Roald Dahl

The farm next to ours is owned by Mr. and Mrs. Gregg. The Greggs have two children, Philip and William. Sometimes I go over to their farm to play with them.

Every Saturday morning Mr. Gregg and his boys would take their guns and go off into the woods to look for animals and birds to shoot.

I can't stand hunting. I just can't stand it. It doesn't seem right to me that [people] should kill animals just for fun. So every time I went over to their farm I would do my best to talk them out of it, but they only laughed and made faces at me, and Mr. Gregg told me to go home and mind my own P's and Q's.

Well, that did it! Before I was able to stop myself, I did something I never meant to do. **I PUT THE MAGIC FINGER ON THEM ALL!**

For months I had been telling myself that I would never put the Magic Finger upon anyone again – Not after what happened to my teacher, old Mrs. Winter.

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INTRODUCTION

Sounds like this story will be anti-hunting . . . and it is. But it's so much more than that. Atticus Finch in To Kill a Mockingbird tells his daughter Scout, "You never really understand a person until you consider things from his point of view, until you climb inside of his skin and walk around in it. Well, in this case, it's ducks instead of people and flying instead of walking, but the message is still the same – Empathy.

Empathy is not some intangible characteristic that some are born with and others are not. We all have the power to truly feel another's struggles, if we only take the time and thought to do so.

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Poor old Mrs. Winter. One day we were in class and she as teaching us spelling.

MRS. WINTER: Stand up and spell cat.

NARRATOR: That's an easy one. K-A-T

MRS. WINTER: You are a stupid little girl! Go and stand in the corner!

Then I got cross and I put the Magic Finger on Mrs. Winter. Guess what? Whiskers began growing out of her face! Just like the ones you see on a cat, only much bigger. Before we had time to think, they were out to her ears!

Of course, the whole class started screaming with laughter.

MRS. WINTER: Will you be so kind as to tell me what you find so madly funny, all of you?

When she turned to write on the blackboard, we saw that she had grown a tail as well! A huge bushy tail!

If any of you are wondering whether Mrs. Winter is quite all right again now, the answer is No. And she never will be.

I can't tell you just how I do it, but it always happens when I get cross. I get very, very hot all over. . then the tip of my finger begins to tingle most terribly . . . and a sort of electric flash comes out of me, jumps out and touches the person who has made me cross. The Magic Finger is upon him or her, and things begin to happen . . .

Well, the Magic Finger was now upon the Gregg family and there was no taking it off again. I ran home and waited for things to happen. I got the whole story from Philip and William the next morning after it was all over . . .

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The afternoon of the very same day, Mr. Gregg, Philip and William went out hunting again. Wild ducks flying very low . . . easy to hit! BANG! BANG! BANG! Went the guns. The ducks flew on.

MR. GREGG: We missed! That's funny

Then to everyone's surprise, the ducks turned around and came flying right back to the guns. They shot at them again, and again they all missed. They stared for home, but the four ducks would not leave them alone. They began flying around and around the hunters as they walked away. Nothing would make them go away.

When morning came, Mr. Gregg was the first to wake up. He sat up and saw what he looked like! *(Mr. Gregg yells)* He was now a tiny little man, maybe as tall as the seat of a chair and where his arms had been, he had a pair of duck's wings instead!

MRS. GREGG: My dear man, what's happened to you?

MR. GREGG: What's happened to both of us, you mean! *(Mrs. Gregg flaps and sobs) (Mr. Gregg quacking and flapping his wings)* This is witches' work!

A minute later Philip and William burst in. The same thing had happened to them. And they were really tine. About as big as robins.

PHILIP: *(quacking)* Mama! Mama! Mama! Look! We can fly!

MRS. GREGG: Come down at once! You're much to high!

But before she could say another word, Philip and William had flown right out the window. Soon the whole family was flying around and around together.

PHILIP: Hey, look down there! Somebody is walking in our garden!

Below them they saw four enormous wild ducks! As big as men. They had great long arms instead of wings and were walking in a line to the door of the Greggs' house. The first one put out a hand and opened the door. The other went in after him.

MRS. GREGG: *(crying)* Oh dear! They have taken our house. What shall we do? We have no place to go! What about food? We haven't had a thing to eat all day!

PHILIP: I will not eat worms! I would rather die!

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MR. GREGG: Disgusting! Just because we have winds, we don't have to eat bird food. We shall eat apples instead. Our trees are full of them. Come on!

But to eat an apple without holding it in your hands is not at all easy. The boys began to cry.

PHILIP: We will be eaten by cats and foxes!

WILLIAM: I want to sleep in my own bed

MR. GREGG: It isn't any good crying. We are going to build a nest! We've got to have somewhere to sleep.

Mrs. Gregg and the children flew off. Soon they were back, carrying sticks in their mouths. The building of the next went on and one. It took a long time, but at last it was finished.

MRS. GREGG: Oh, isn't it lovely! I might lay an egg any moment.

About this time, I picked up the telephone and tried to call Philip to see if the family as all right.

NARRATOR: Hello? (Quack) Who is it? (Quack Quack)

It was like a bird laughing. That Magic Finger . . . what has it done to my friends?!

At last morning came.

MRS. GREGG: Thank goodness! I never want to sleep in a nest again.

She got up and looked over the side . . . On the ground below them stood the four enormous ducks and three of them were holding guns in their hands.

MR. GREGG: No! No! No! Don't shoot!

DUCK: Why not? You are always shooting at us

MR. GREGG: But that's not the same! We are ***allowed*** to shoot ducks!

DUCK: Who allows you?

MR. GREGG: We allow each other.

DUCK: Very nice. And now we are going to ***allow*** each other to shoot you!

I would have loved to have seen Mr. Gregg's face just then.

MR. GREGG: Oh, please! My two little children are up here with us. You wouldn't shoot my children!

DUCK: Yesterday you shot my children. All six of my children.

MR. GREGG: I'll never do it again. Never, never, never! I'll never shoot another duck as long as I live.

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DUCK: That is not good enough. What about deer?

MR. GREGG: I'll do anything you say if you will only put down those guns. I'll never shoot anything!

DUCK: Will you throw away your guns?

MR. GREGG: I will break them into tiny bits!

DUCK: Very well. You may come down. And by the way, may I congratulate you on the next. For a first effort it's pretty good.

Then all at once everything went black. A funny feeling came over them all and thy heard a great wind. The black turned to blue, to green, to red and then to gold, and suddenly, there they were, standing in their own garden and everything was back to normal. Philip and William began dancing about with joy. High above their head, they heard the call of a wild duck. (Quack)

About half an hour later, I walked into the Greggs' garden to see how things were going, and I must admit I was expecting the worst.

Mr. Gregg was smashing all three guns into tiny pieces with a huge hammer. Mrs. Gregg was placing beautiful flowers upon sixteen tiny mounds of soil, which

I learned were the graves of the ducks that had been shot before. And in the middle of the yard Philip and William were surrounded by ducks, doves, pigeons, sparrows, robins, and larks. The birds were eating the barley that the boys were scattering by the handful.

NARRATOR: Good morning, Mr. Gregg

MR. GREGG: *(stops hammering)* My name is not Gregg any more. In honor of my feathered friends, I have changed it to Egg.

NARRATOR: What happened? *(to audience)* They seemed to have gone completely dotty . . . all four of them.

WILLIAM: Look! There's the next! Can you see it? That's where we slept last night.

MR. EGG: *(proudly)* I built it all myself. Every stick of it.

Just then, from somewhere over by the lake there came a loud BANG! Suddenly I got very hot all over . . . the tip of my finger began tingling. I could feel the power building up inside me. I turned and started running towards the lake as fast as I could.

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MR. EGG: Hey! Where are you going?

NARRATOR: To find the Coopers! Wait and see. They'll be nesting in the trees tonight, every one of them!

NATIONAL USE

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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